



Most Popular Duo!

Google Duo becomes most popular Free App in the Play Store
<http://dgit.in/DuoTopPS>



McDonalds Step it

McDonalds is giving free fitness trackers with Happy Meals in Canada.
<http://dgit.in/McDSWtch>

From the labs

Puzzlephone

Puzzlephone is perhaps the most modular of all the models currently available. It gives you the freedom to upgrade parts of it-adding faster processors as well as better batteries. For the ones who like their visuals in all enriched glory, better screens can also be added. As per the company's CEO, Alejandro Santacreu, this Android phone has a lifespan of about 10 years, a far leap from the two years or so enjoyed with your smartphone.

Fairphone 2

Critics are already beating down on the Fairphone 2 regarding its looks (and to be fair-no pun intended- it does look a couple of decades old for something that's supposed to be part of the future). However the Fairphone 2 isn't without merits- it's acutely environment conscious, its components ethically sourced. Many of its hardware components can be replaced by the end user. If multiple vendors could pitch in



Perhaps the most modular among the current fray

to provide the replaceable parts of the phone, it could go down well with the mainstream users.

RePhone kit

Rephone kit from the Chinese tech company, Seeed Studio is what one might term as a 'sideways' approach to the modular phone. In fact, the kit isn't a phone at all but comes with a small, economical screen and an open source OS. You can add cellular capabilities to applications without the prohibitive prices that would be the case with regular smartphones. Added bonus:

it gives a template with which you can build the enclosure from multiple materials-including cardboard, leather or 3D printed hard case.

LG G5

'Modular puritans- those who think that modular phones as envisioned in the early stages of ideation, the ones which you can practically take apart and replace with entirely new set of parts from top to bottom, are the only ones truly worth the name may find G5 way less than modular. But the phone does give its share of modularity-for instance, the hi-fi and camera could be replaced. The battery compartment is also removable. Yes, if the phone were to put that down in a resume, it wouldn't look all that impressive. But for the mainstream users, this could be a first taste of things to come.

Motorola Moto Z

Motorola, like any other company in the modular fray, wanted to expand



Rethink what a phone is. No, really.

the idea of what a phone does. Hence, the Moto Z. The 'mods' in the system include a JBL SoundBoost speaker, Incipio OffGrid Power Pack and also Moto Insta-Share Projector. All the mods can be attached to the Moto Z using magnets. The mods connect comfortably enough though only one mod can be connected at a time.

The stumbling blocks

While the tech world-which is just about everyone living in the urban centers of the world-is excited at the idea of modular phones and the fact that major companies have come up

with their initial variants, certain stumbling blocks stand in the way of modular phones and their widespread adoption by the mainstream users.

Some of the major ones are:

Lack of standardization

Standardization is the key for facilitating mass consumption. At the risk of sounding simplistic, it's like coming to a consensus that sugar is best for coffee and not salt. Once you have that cleared, coffee consumption is bound to increase. Unfortunately for the modular phone industry, no common norm exists at this point of time. This makes the number of modules available with a product rather limited. On the bright side, even though standardization is an issue currently, it's not at all insurmountable.

The 'awareness cost' on the consumer

Modular phone obviously means you have to grapple with a whole lot of units on your phone. This sort of implies that you need to keep a tab on the upgrade options of individual modules, which could be overwhelming, to say the least. God only knows that keeping track of all the advancements in phone-as a singular unit is hard in itself. Whether the consumer would be willing to incur this psychological cost will be a key factor in deciding the future of modular phones.

The monetary cost

The thing that makes the world go round, also determines to a large extent the shape of things to come. As far as



One of the major entries, at least in theory